B1 Grammar

Articles: a, an, the or no article

When to use a, an, the or no article at all, with the slip Arabic speakers make most.

English has two articles: *a/an* (indefinite) and *the* (definite). Many nouns also take no article at all. The choice depends on whether the listener knows which thing you mean.

Article	Use	Example
a / an	One thing, mentioned for the first time	*I saw a dog in the park.*
a / an	Jobs and descriptions	*She's an engineer. It's a good idea.*
the	Something already mentioned, or clear from the situation	*The dog was huge. Can you close the door?*
the	Only one exists; superlatives; ordinal numbers	*the sun, the best day, the first time*
no article	Plural and uncountable nouns used in general	*Dogs are loyal. Water is essential.*

A or an? Choose by sound, not spelling: *a university* (you-), *a one-way ticket* (wun-), *an hour* (silent h), *an MBA* (em-).

Common mistake. Arabic uses *al-* for general ideas, so learners write *The life is hard* or *I like the coffee*. In English, general ideas take no article: *Life is hard. I like coffee.*

Practice

1. I bought ___ new laptop last week. ___ laptop is very fast.
2. She wants to be ___ architect.
3. ___ honesty is important in ___ friendship.

4. This is ___ best film I've ever seen.
5. We stayed in ___ hotel near ___ Nile.
6. Correct the mistake: The children need the love and the attention.

▼ Show answers

1. a, The
2. an
3. no article, no article (Honesty is important in friendship.)
4. the
5. a, the (rivers take *the*)
6. Children need love and attention.